



GIRISH GV

LAW ABIDING: Students of NLSIU, Bangalore, taking lessons

programme, students are placed with NGOs, national and international institutions, lawyers, judges of high courts and the Supreme Court, law firms, corporates and international agencies like the UNHCR, UNICEF, Centre for GATT Studies and the International Red Cross. They are sent with express placement goals and are required to submit a report on the placement when they return. It is the only law school that pays 50 per cent of the travel cost for students to attend international conferences and has sent 100-odd abroad in the past five years. The only pre-condition: present a substantive research paper on return. It also has a special scheme to help indigent students.

NLSIU, which is 10 years older than

NALSAR, also addresses all-round development concerns in its five-year graduate programme. Each outgoing batch of students elects a recruitment coordination committee, which networks with advocates, law firms, including foreign recruiters and companies. Some, exposed to social action concerns as students, opt for academics or enlist with NGOs.

After developing its computerised library system, NLSIU is now working to establish a network of law libraries in India and eventually a National Legal Information Centre, a sort of clearing house which will be immensely useful when it creates an e-law school. "Our idea is to offer an e-law school the facilities of which can be tapped by many more people," says NLSIU Vice-Chancellor Professor A. Jayagovind. As part of this initiative, the school is already subscribing to international

online databases. CLC, Delhi, which has moved up to the third position, has for the first time this year launched a placement assistance council.

Whatever their rankings, law schools, unlike other streams of education, are fast catching up with the demand by offering relevant courses that have prompted companies to keep competent legal eagles on their rolls. At the same time, the schools also face common constraints. Growth is hampered for want of funds. NALSAR, for one, hopes to raise finances by starting diploma courses in patent laws, cyber laws, media laws and other specialised laws which are of particular interest to diverse professions. The other constraint is attracting competent faculty which can be overcome only by offering better salaries so that the talented are drawn to teaching too.

with Stephen David and Kanika Tandon



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